sensitive as civil nuclear energy cooperation and defence equipment speaks for the growing comfort levels.

The conduct of serious military exercises annually by two nations would be no small matter in any case. Given that Japan is a partner, it is in fact exceptional progress. Far from being politically controversial, this is perceived in India as contributing to larger stability and security. The conclusion of a logistics exchange agreement, agreed to in principle in 2019, has the potential of taking cooperation to a new level. Their greater responsiveness to each other's regional concerns has been publicly expressed. Interests in non-proliferation, counterterrorism and maritime security are more visibly coordinated. The gruelling experience of seeking a revision in the composition of the UN Security Council has brought them closer. Horizons of cooperation have now expanded and even extend to third countries. Perhaps the most remarkable fact is that Japan is involved in many of the bolder diplomatic initiatives we have undertaken, including the Quad, a 2+2 foreign-defence consultation and a trilateral with Australia.

While few would have predicted that the political facet of this relationship would lead the economic one some day, it is not that the latter has really been slowing down either. Japan had traditionally made Official Development Assistance (ODA) the centrepiece of its strategy. This has been significantly expanded and, in fact, these ODA projects have been among the most successfully executed in the country in the present times. Flagship initiatives include Metro projects that have transformed urban management and the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor that can multiply industrial production. Additional freight and industrial corridors are on the drawing board and their importance to addressing India's logistical bottlenecks is significant.

On the business side, there has been a perceptible expansion in the presence of Japanese companies in India and a stronger commitment by those already there. The enabling environment for them has been significantly improved with specific initiatives to improve their living conditions and travel. More significantly, the two countries have been working on enhancing the quality of skills and training necessary for Japanese requirements. Industrial townships, training institutes, language centres and special finance facilities